# What the product actually does

Cranston takes the production work between a messy client package and a professional review, then makes that work traceable, repeatable, and easier to inspect.

A tax preparer normally opens the prior return, inspects the current documents and books, decides what belongs where, builds or updates workpapers, enters values into tax software, runs the calculation, and creates a list of missing information and judgment items. Cranston is software for doing more of that production work before the reviewer begins.

## THE THREE-PART PRODUCT MODEL

### 1. Understand the package

Cranston uses the current source files, prior-year return and workpapers, books where relevant, and firm instructions. It classifies the documents and identifies missing, duplicate, wrong-year, unreadable, inconsistent, or questionable items. This is not just OCR. OCR extracts text; preparation decides what the evidence means in the return workflow.

### 2. Prepare supported work

Cranston maps supported values, assembles workpapers, tracks year-over-year changes, and prepares the draft through a verified tax-software path. The system keeps the source behind the number visible and separates routine work from items that require a professional decision.

### 3. Hand control to the reviewer

The output is a source-linked draft, workpapers, diagnostics, and an exception queue. The firm's preparer or reviewer inspects the work, resolves judgment, requests missing information, approves the return, obtains authorization, signs, and files.

## WHY THAT MATTERS

- A reviewer can follow a number back to its document, page, spreadsheet range, or ledger support.
- Open questions are visible before they become review notes or filing surprises.
- The firm keeps its tax engine, templates, and responsibility instead of migrating to a new filing system.
- Preparation capacity can grow without adding proportional junior, seasonal, or offshore headcount.

> The product promise is not 'AI fills forms.' It is 'messy package in; supported, reviewable work out.'

# From intake to the firm's tax engine

A product conversation is clearer when it follows one return in order. Setup, package analysis, preparation, calculation, review, and filing are different stages.

1. **Qualify the corridor.** Confirm the form, tax year, tax software product and edition, hosting environment, source-package format, and who controls installation and test data.
2. **Bring in the engagement context.** Use the current client package, prior-year material, books where relevant, and the firm's preparation or review instructions.
3. **Organize and test the evidence.** Classify documents, remove duplicates, catch wrong-year or unreadable files, compare with prior year, and surface missing items.
4. **Build the preparation layer.** Extract supported values, map accounts and forms, create workpapers, record sources, and isolate judgment or uncertainty.
5. **Write through the supported path.** Move approved or supported entries into the relevant tax-software workflow, run calculation or retrieve output where verified, and return diagnostics.
6. **Review, revise, and file.** The professional inspects the draft and sources, clears questions, makes tax decisions, obtains client authorization, and files through the firm's normal process.

## THREE PROOF STAGES THAT MUST NOT BE CONFUSED

- **Browser or Cranston analysis:** Cranston can understand the package and show proposed work. This proves preparation logic, not destination integration.
- **Output in Cranston's licensed tax environment:** the return can be calculated or reviewed in a controlled supported environment. This is stronger product proof, but it is not yet the buyer's installation.
- **Live write in the buyer's environment:** values land in a duplicate or test client inside the buyer's actual software and hosting setup. This is the meaningful integration proof.

## CURRENT BOUNDARIES TO REMEMBER

Core federal focus is 1040, 1065, 1120, and 1120-S. Current implementation evidence is strongest for Drake Tax Online and CCH Axcess. Intake and supporting data may involve Canopy, Truss, QuickBooks, Xero, Sage, Gmail, Drive, or OneDrive. Lacerte is environment-specific. Do not infer a live production path from a logo or marketing page, and do not promise universal coverage.

> The safe sentence is: 'Support depends on the form, year, engine, edition, hosting, and workflow. We will confirm that corridor before the test.'

# Show one return, one source trail, one decision

A strong demo is a coherent story about a return. It should not become a tour of every screen or a parade of AI features.

## BEFORE THE DEMO

- Know who is attending and what they own: preparation, review, operations, technology, or the purchase.
- Know the firm's return mix, tax engine, hosting setup, workpaper process, and stated bottleneck.
- Choose a return and workflow that match what you have confirmed. Do not improvise support in the room.
- Decide the next proof step before the call so the demo has somewhere to go.

## THE DEMO SEQUENCE

1. **Restate the problem.** 'You said the issue is not raw data entry; it is the cleanup and source hunting your reviewers inherit.' Make the buyer feel understood before showing software.
2. **Introduce the package.** Show the current files and prior-year context. Explain what the system expects and what it immediately recognizes as missing, duplicated, or questionable.
3. **Follow one number.** Open a tax value, show the source document or ledger support behind it, and show how the reviewer can inspect the trail.
4. **Show an exception.** Use one missing item, year-over-year anomaly, diagnostic, or uncertain treatment. Explain that Cranston flags what it cannot safely resolve.
5. **Show the draft in context.** Demonstrate the workpaper, return output, or verified destination-software step. Be exact about whether this is analysis, Cranston's environment, or the buyer's environment.
6. **End with reviewer control.** Show what the professional reviews, changes, approves, or sends back. Filing remains downstream of professional approval.

## WHAT NOT TO DO

- Do not narrate every click. Explain the accounting problem each screen solves.
- Do not say 'fully automated,' 'works with everything,' or 'the AI knows.' Describe evidence, controls, and the supported mechanism.
- Do not hide an integration limitation. Precision earns more trust than a vague yes.
- Do not finish with 'any questions?' Finish with a proposed representative return and a scheduled review step.

> The demo should answer four questions: What did Cranston receive? What work did it do? What remains for the professional? Where does the result land?

# The first call earns the next proof step

Discovery makes the demo relevant. The demo makes a representative test feel safe. The test proves whether the product belongs in the firm's actual workflow.

## THE CALL IN FOUR MOVES

1. **Start with why now.** Why did they book, who feels the pain, and what would make the conversation useful?
2. **Locate the workflow.** Ask about form mix and volume, tax software and hosting, intake, workpapers, preparers, reviewers, handoffs, bottlenecks, urgency, and decision ownership.
3. **Demo the relevant path.** Show the source trail, preparation output, exception handling, and precise destination step that map to their problem.
4. **Agree on proof.** Choose the return, confirm authorization and support, define success, include the real operator and reviewer, and put the output review on the calendar.

## QUESTIONS THAT SOUND LIKE YOU UNDERSTAND THE JOB

- What return types create the most reviewer cleanup: 1040s, pass-throughs, or both?
- Do business returns start from clean books, a mapped trial balance, or a package your tax team still has to repair?
- Where does a normal return stall: missing client documents, preparation, review notes, or destination-software entry?
- What does the reviewer check first, and what work does the preparer usually create for them?
- Which workpaper, source-trail, or control point must remain in the process?
- What would one return need to prove for the operator and reviewer to use this again?

## A GOOD TEST AND PILOT

Start with a **completed, reviewed return** so Cranston's output can be compared with a known answer. Use a representative package, not a canned easy 1040, and include a business return or meaningful irregularity when that is the firm's pain. Confirm form, year, software edition, hosting, data authorization, and installation ownership before accepting files.

If the first return is useful, move to a measured batch such as 25 to 50 returns. Track reviewer minutes, open items, source traceability, unnecessary findings, business mappings, and clean destination-engine output. The goal is not a dramatic demo. It is evidence that the workflow saves time after a skeptical professional checks it.

## TRUST BOUNDARIES

Use the approved secure-transfer workflow for taxpayer data. Cranston's SOC 2 examination is in progress; do not say certified. Do not improvise answers about hosting, subprocessors, retention, training, or data location. If you do not know, say what you will verify and own the follow-up.

> The demo creates interest. Their own return creates belief. Traceable output landing safely in the actual engine creates trust.

Basis: Cranston standing context, current implementation evidence, product materials, and raw bodies from the 50 most recent accessible Granola meetings reviewed August 2026. Product support and security status can change; live enablement governs promises.